



## See through a Dolphin's eyes

Researchers have managed to generate a highly enhanced image of what a dolphin could be seeing through their eyes <http://dgit.in/HowDolphinsSee>

## Virtual trial room

You can now use your Xbox One and a Kinect to try on clothes virtually, promises The Mall, a new shopping app <http://dgit.in/VirtualFitting>

Industry Connect

# You could become the next self published literary sensation

We speak to Neal Thompson, Director of Author and Publishing Relations at Amazon, on the ways in which budding writers can use Kindle's Direct Publishing (KDP) platform to quickly push their books to market



Neal Thompson, Director of Author and Publishing Relations at Amazon

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### **d** How does one start with KDP?

**Neil:** So kindledirectpublishing.com is where you start. You just set-up an account, and it will walk you through the steps to publishing your own book. Some of the benefits of it are that it's entirely in your control. There are tools there that help you to format it. Change the font, change the layout, there are preview tools that show you how your book will look on different devices. You can play with images, sizes, and more. Whenever you are ready, it will process the file and you are ready to go. We have a cover creator tool as well, using which you can design your own cover if you don't have one already. What's exciting about it is that all of it is completely DIY. All the controls are in your hands and you don't have to wait for the permissions from the publisher. You don't have to go through the traditional route of finding an agent, finding a publisher, you know you can be up and running in a day!

### **d** What does Amazon do from its side to help publicise these budding authors?

**Neil:** There are few programs that you can enroll in that will help the book get featured. One is called KDP select. If you sell your book exclusively in the Kindle

store, you will get sort of extra promotional perk from Amazon. You can run promotional deals, like a countdown deal where say you lower the price for five days and it incentivises people to buy at that lower price and the books that are enrolled in that count down deal program are featured on a special page on Amazon. Related to that KDP select program, there is another subscription reading program we have launched just in September this year in India called Kindle Unlimited. It's a great program and there is a lot of promise for it in India. For ₹199 per month people who are voracious readers can sign-up for this subscription program at Kindle Unlimited and read as many books as they want. So if your book is enrolled in KDP select, it's also available in KU. Promoting books and getting readers to find the book is a challenge for every author no matter how they are published – traditionally or self published. I've written four books myself and it has always been a problem but the digitization of storytelling and books have made it a whole lot easier to reach a global audience and to do so fast.

### **d** Is there a kind of a voting or a peer review process that gets books noticed?

**Neil:** In terms of getting your book published, there is no review at all. As for the publicising the book more the flywheel

effect kicks in. Say you get your friends to write reviews you get that flywheel spinning a little bit, because on Amazon, books that have more reviews and better reviews, the algorithm decides what books get featured higher up the scale and would pay attention to those reviews and start automatically featuring that book up the chain, so it's pushing it up the chain. So increased sales, great reviews.

### **d** Have there been any success stories through this platform? Like authors hitting the NYT bestseller lists?

**Neil:** Yes, so one of the books that we were talking about was fifty shades of grey. It started as a self publish KDP and later it got the attention of a traditional publisher and then they published it in hardcover and paper. On my trip here we met an Indian guy who has some quarter million downloads for all the books he has written.

### **d** Speaking of stats can you share some?

**Neil:** I can tell you that of top 100 Kindle books on Amazon in India, 20 of them are self published. In other markets like the European markets it's up to 33% in France and almost 50% in Germany. Self publishing books used to be viewed as vanity project, people doing their own books but now they are best sellers. **d**

(Blipp this page for the full interview)